# The Gulf of Tonkin Resolution

*President Lyndon B. Johnson & the U.S. Congress · August 1964*

*Source: Joint Resolution of Congress H.J. RES 1145 (1964). Public domain. Continuous passage.*

> After reported attacks on U.S. ships, Congress authorized the President "to take all necessary measures" in Southeast Asia — the legal foundation for the escalation of the Vietnam War.

Resolved by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled, That the Congress approves and supports the determination of the President, as Commander in Chief, to take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack against the forces of the United States and to prevent further aggression.

[ . . . ]

Section 2. The United States regards as vital to its national interest and to world peace the maintenance of international peace and security in southeast Asia. Consonant with the Constitution of the United States and the Charter of the United Nations and in accordance with its obligations under the Southeast Asia Collective Defense Treaty, the United States is, therefore, prepared, as the President determines, to take all necessary steps, including the use of armed force, to assist any member or protocol state of the Southeast Asia Collective Defense Treaty requesting assistance in defense of its freedom. Section 3. This resolution shall expire when the President shall determine that the peace and security of the area is reasonably assured by international conditions created by action of the United Nations or otherwise, except that it may be terminated earlier by concurrent resolution of the Congress.